



Nokia's Booklet 3G, a netbook launched in the European markets, runs Windows 7



On Dec 17, Intel's Indian branch unveiled a prototype 48 core processor meant specially for cloud computing

Cloudburst

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What is Chrome OS?

Chrome OS is Google's attempt to bring it's minimalistic sensibilities to the Operating System. Operating Systems are designed to run on a wide range of hardware, support a large number of devices, and run on constantly changing configurations. This means that the code used for the Operating System generally has a ton of checks to utilise each and every piece of hardware to an optimum level. This is just in theory, and we all know how buggy this is in practice. Chrome is probably one of the few Operating Systems where everything is stripped down to the bare essentials. Designed for a narrow range of hardware, this compromise is in favour of performance. Chrome is designed for the particular niche of netbook users who spend most of their time in the clouds. One of the primary guiding philosophies of Chrome is that you are on the internet when you turn your computer on. This explains the almost startling sub 7 second boot time (It's true, we checked), and the fact that your Google username is also your account name on your system. There is almost nothing on the operating system apart from the Chrome browser.

Chrome OS is not a competitor to other companies that make Operating System for the netbook segment. Chrome OS is just one of the many exciting new platforms for Mobile Internet Devices (MIDs). Moblin, a Linux distribution by Intel for it's Atom processor, eyeOS, a cloud-based OS to be distributed with IBM machines from this month, and Google's own Android are just some examples. The web is growing at such a pace that there is enough room for everyone, including the smaller players to get a hold on different aspects of the web.

In fact, the way things are going, services by Google, Microsoft and others will very likely be intercompatible with each other. A demo video of Chrome had a Google employee quipping of a "new application for Chrome by Microsoft", which was an online version of Microsoft's office suite. In fact, all the competition is better for Google. Even if there is a netbook based cloud OS that gets more popular than Chrome OS, Google still stands to benefit, simply because of it's strong hold over the internet. Chrome OS is open source, and the reason Google is investing efforts into it, is that their primary aim is to get people online. As long as people are online, they will probably be using a Google service, which is the reason for a lot of generosity on Google's side, including free Wi-Fi access to a lot of American airports. Google is dramatically not venturing into some other areas of the web, an example would be back-end platforms for cloud applications, such as Microsoft's Azure operating system.

At this stage, Chrome OS is the browser Chrome installed on a skeletal Ubuntu system, with a few bells and whistles. This is all that Chrome looks like it will ever be, and Chrome is barely an operating system in the traditional sense. For the break-in period, Chrome OS will very likely be bundled with a "normal" OS, either another Linux flavour, or with a Windows installation, as is done with Android net-

Google's Chrome OS is not even on the horizon, but the hype has reached an almost rabid frenzy. Here, we separate the facts from the faff

books now. Chrome OS is still very much in the development phase, with code being put in regularly. The source code is available for anyone to download and use. While Chrome OS is not the first cloud operating system, it is the most widely publicised, and a hands-on reveals that there are many things that users will end up doing differently.

How to get Chrome OS

Do you want to test drive Chrome OS for yourself? Here is how:

1

It is best to start with an Ubuntu system. Go to <http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/14984/>. Download the latest source code, which will be in a tarball or ZIP archive.

2

Download scripts from the Google Chrome OS site that let you compile Chrome OS on a USB drive, then boot from it. Complete instructions are available at <http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/83057/>.

3

Plug in the USB drive to your computer, hit [F12] to enter the boot menu, and select boot from USB drive. Enter your Google account details.

4

Alternatively, you can search for a pre-compiled Chrome OS disk image, then load the image in a virtual machine such as VirtualBox. Download a torrent file from <http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/15730/>, and unzip it to a directory. Then, start up VirtualBox, and choose an existing disk image, and load the file you downloaded.